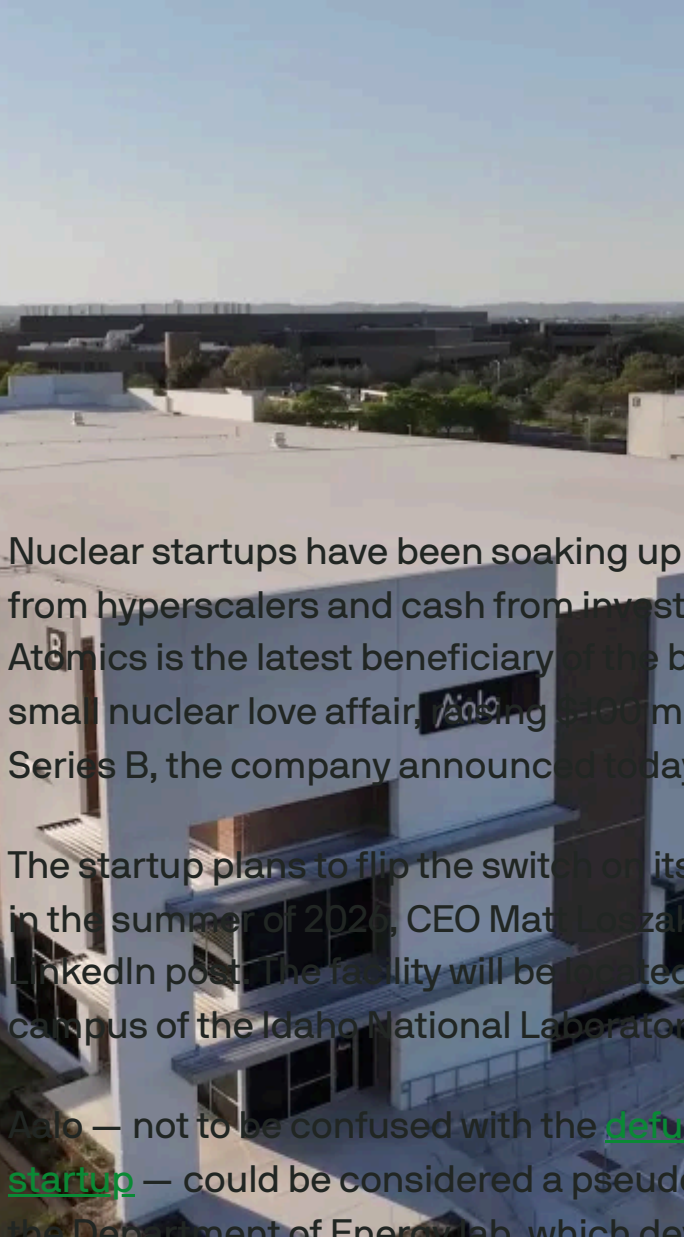


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**Aalo Atomics raises
\$100M to build a
microreactor and data
center together**



Nuclear startups have been soaking up attention from hyperscalers and cash from investors. Aalo Atomics is the latest beneficiary of the big tech-small nuclear love affair, [raising \\$100 million](#) in a Series B, the company announced today.

The startup plans to flip the switch on its first reactor in the summer of 2026, CEO Matt Boszak [said](#) in a LinkedIn post. The facility will be located on the campus of the Idaho National Laboratory.

Aalo — not to be confused with the [defunct furniture startup](#) — could be considered a pseudo-spinout of the Department of Energy lab, which developed and open-sourced a small modular reactor design called Marvel. The company's CTO, Yasir Arafat, previously led Marvel's design, which Aalo says "inspired" its prototype. Aalo also received [development support](#) from the Idaho National Lab as part of an Obama administration program to accelerate nuclear reactor development.

The Series B round was led by Valor Equity Partners with participation from 50Y, Alumni Ventures, Crescent Enterprises, Crosscut, Fine Structure Ventures, Gaingels, Harpoon Ventures, Hitachi Ventures, Kindred Ventures, MCJ, NRG Energy, Nucleation Capital, Perpetual VC, Tishman Speyer, and Vamos Ventures.

If Aalo can meet its aggressive deadline, it would buck a trend in the nuclear industry, which has a

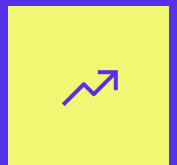
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history of long timelines compounded by delays.

Like many advanced nuclear startups, Aalo is counting on economies of scale to help rein in both costs and build times. If the company can prove its approach works, it says it will build thousands of Aalo Pod power plants, which will consist of five Aalo-1 reactors delivering heat to a single turbine to generate a total of 50 megawatts of electricity.

The startup says that the Aalo-X prototype will also have an “experimental” data center built next door, a detail that sounds more like a marketing ploy than a technological innovation.

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Ultimately, Aalo says it aims to deliver electricity at three cents per kilowatt-hour, a price that would [make it competitive](#) with new natural gas power plants and solar farms built today. The startup hasn’t put a timeline on that price, though, a wise move given the nuclear industry’s [previous promises](#).

Aalo isn't the only nuclear startup making news this week. Yesterday, Kairos said that the Tennessee Valley Authority agreed to buy 50 megawatts of generating capacity from its Hermes 2 power plant, which the startup is planning to build in Oak Ridge, Tennessee. Google, in turn, will use that power to drive its data centers.

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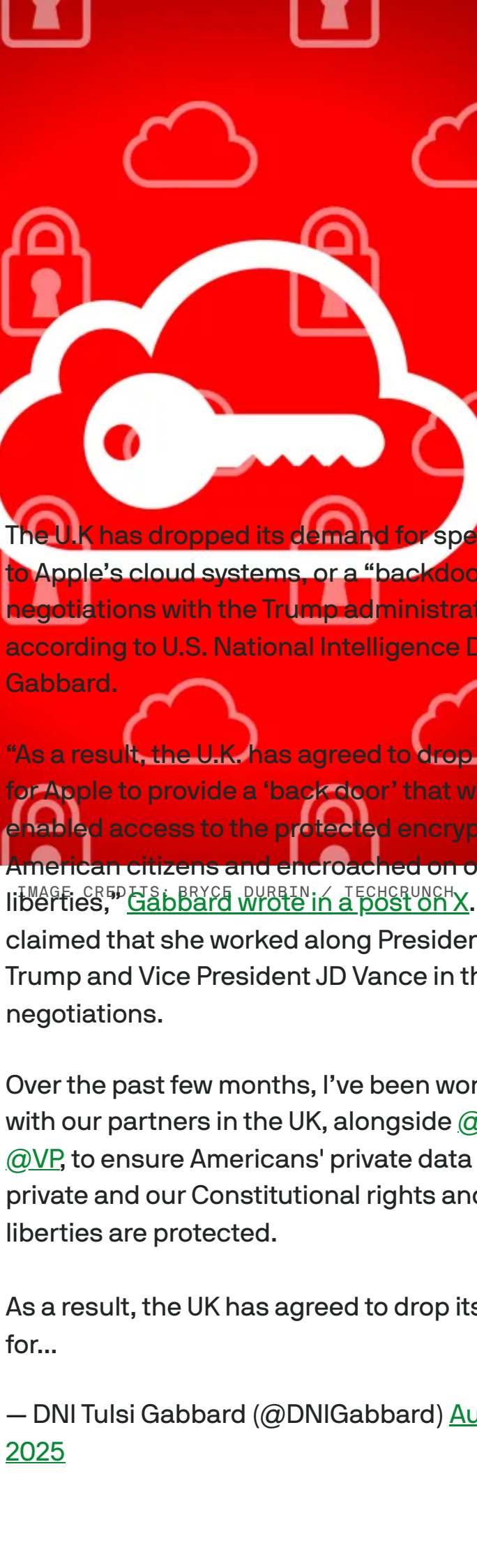
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US spy chief says UK has dropped its Apple

backdoor demand

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 7:25 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



The U.K has dropped its demand for special access to Apple’s cloud systems, or a “backdoor,” following negotiations with the Trump administration, according to U.S. National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard.

“As a result, the U.K. has agreed to drop its mandate for Apple to provide a ‘back door’ that would have enabled access to the protected encrypted data of American citizens and encroached on our civil liberties,” [Gabbard wrote in a post on X](#). She also claimed that she worked along President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance in the negotiations.

Over the past few months, I’ve been working closely with our partners in the UK, alongside [@POTUS](#) and [@VP](#), to ensure Americans' private data remains private and our Constitutional rights and civil liberties are protected.

As a result, the UK has agreed to drop its mandate for...

— DNI Tulsi Gabbard (@DNIGabbard) [August 19, 2025](#)

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This is the latest (and unexpected) development in a months-long saga that saw the British government secretly demanding Apple grant its authorities access — essentially asking for a [backdoor](#) — to the encrypted data of iCloud users, effectively anywhere in the world, particularly those who turn on [Advanced Data Protection](#) (or ADP), an opt-in security feature. ADP [turns on end-to-end encryption](#) for iCloud, meaning only the user can access their files stored on Apple’s cloud servers.

The existence of the legal demand was first reported by [The Washington Post](#) in February, which was made under the [U.K.’s Investigatory Powers Act 2016](#), also known as the Snoopers’ Charter. The request [sparked outrage and condemnation](#) from privacy and security experts worldwide, who argued that if the U.K. government obtained what it wanted, it would weaken privacy for the whole world, and also open the door for more governments to make similar demands, even in other companies’ technologies.

[Apple initially responded by removing ADP from the U.K.](#), meaning new users couldn’t turn it on. The company also said it would give guidance to existing users who “will eventually need to disable this security feature.”

In the meantime, Apple also [reportedly challenged the backdoor mandate](#) in court, a case that was initially secret but [was then ruled to be held in public](#).

Apple and the U.K. Home Office, which initiated the demand on behalf of the British government, did not respond to requests for comment.

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Olivia Coleman, the press secretary of the U.S. Office of the Director of National Intelligence, referred to a February letter to Sen. Wyden and Rep. Biggs.

Apple previously told TechCrunch that the company has “never built a backdoor or master key” to any of its products or services and it “never will.”

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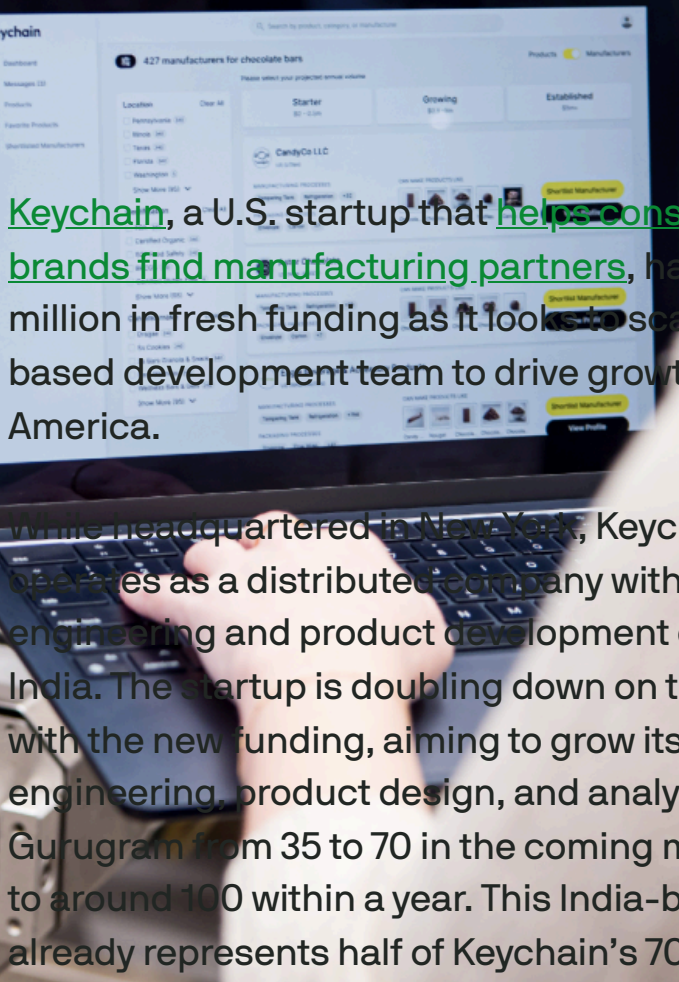
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ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain
snags \$30M to build in
India, grow in the U.S.



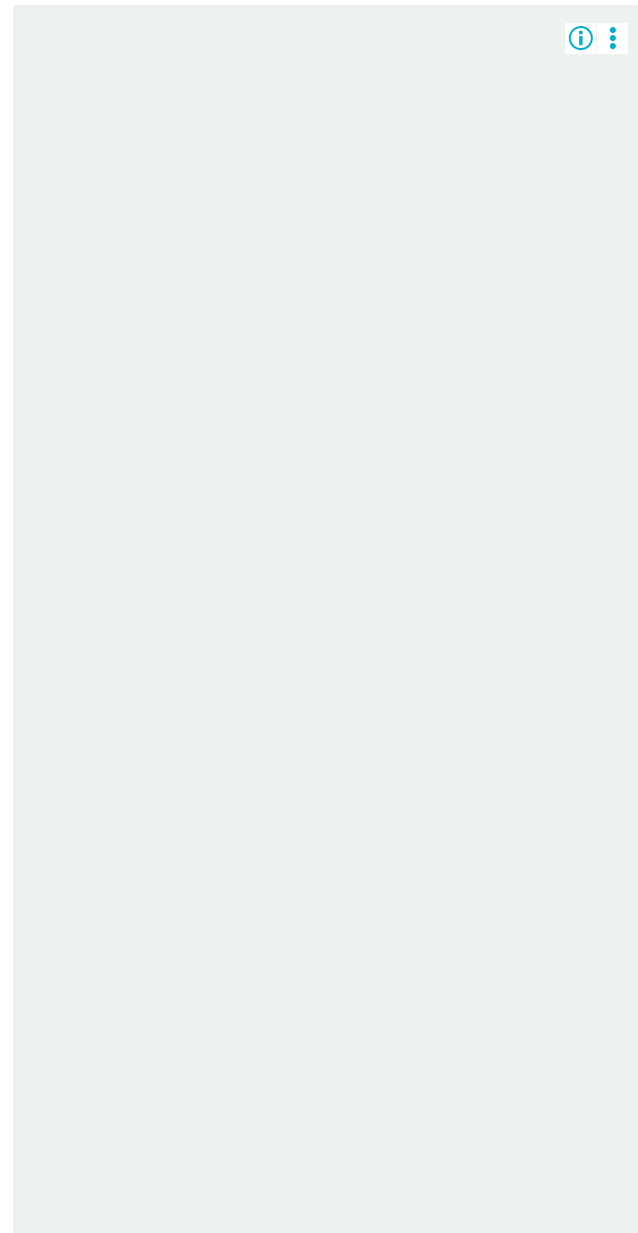
Keychain, a U.S. startup that helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners, has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team already represents half of Keychain's 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in Gurugram — which is the country's second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

"It's the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and



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Aalo Atomics raises \$100M to build a microreactor and data center together

Tim De Chant - 6 minutes ago

availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

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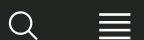
Kirsten Korosec - 15 hours ago



KEYCHAIN CO-FOUNDERS JORDAN WEITZ, OISIN HANRAHAN, AND UMANG DUA (LEFT TO RIGHT)

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

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we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is

just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes,” Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



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Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK’s [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia’s [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India’s tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India’s position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-

founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

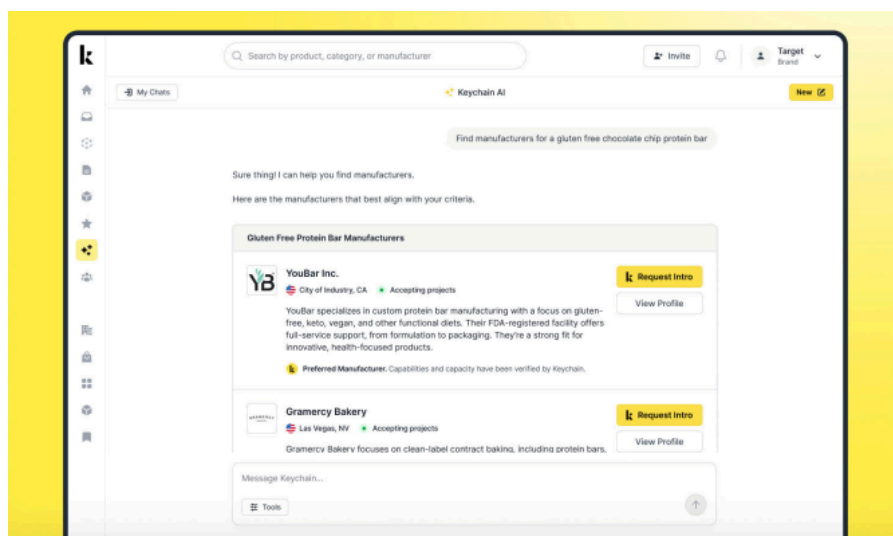
Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and

discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.



KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

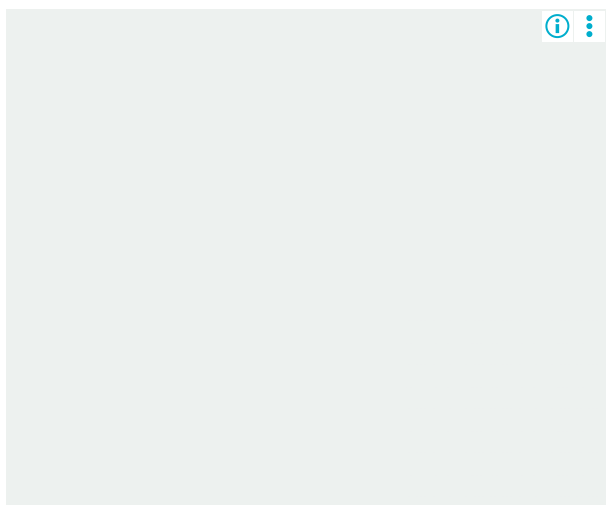
Keychain’s Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total.

Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025



In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have

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added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

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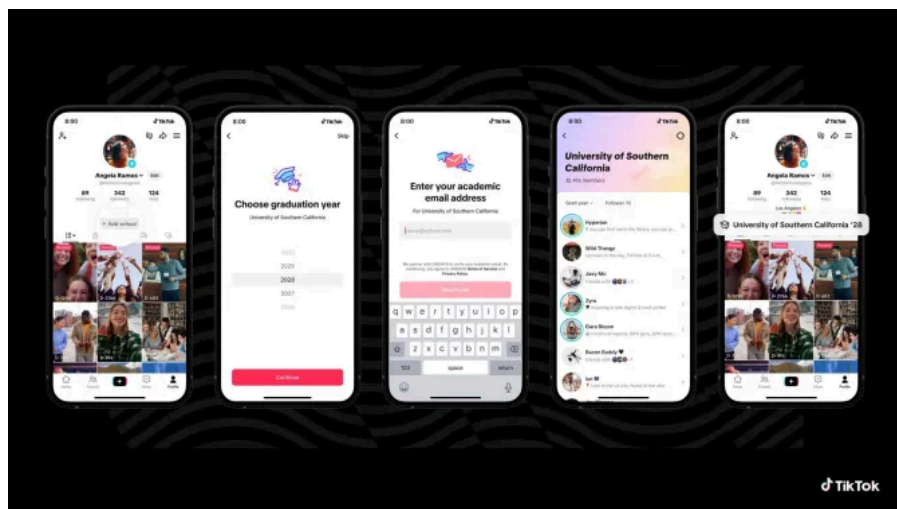


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok's partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook's original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok's new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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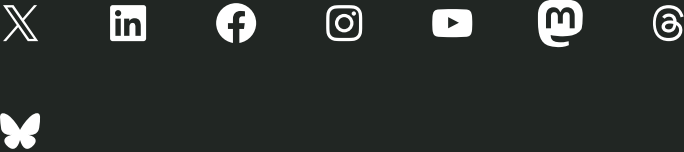
Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [🐼](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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